

## ET.PM3 – PROJECT MANAGEMENT (SW3)

### 1 High Level Planning

1. Think beyond your first approach idea. Explore thinking small and explore thinking big.
2. Fill in the blank part of the sentence below to help understand the actual completion point of your project.

*This project will be completed successfully when...*

*... is done.*

### 2 Project Flexibility Profile

| Mark the level of flexibility for each constraint | Inflexible, rigid | adaptable, negotiable | flexible |
|---------------------------------------------------|-------------------|-----------------------|----------|
| SCOPE/QUALITY                                     |                   |                       |          |
| COSTS                                             |                   |                       |          |
| SCHEDULE/TIME                                     |                   |                       |          |

### 3 Reading 1: “Project Management Pitfalls & How to Avoid Them”

(adapted from *visualplanning.com*)

Project management is about guiding a team toward clear outcomes while staying adaptable. Even experienced managers stumble into hidden traps that throw off delivery and frustrate stakeholders. This article examines the most common pitfalls in project management.

#### 1. Lack of Clear Objectives

Projects without defined goals tend to drift. When teams don't know what they're working toward, every decision becomes a debate. Conflicting priorities surface. Accountability fades. Clear, measurable objectives act like a roadmap. They keep everyone aligned, guide daily actions, and instill confidence in the project's direction among stakeholders. Without them, even the best resources can't deliver results. Successful plans start with clarity. Without it, you're navigating in the dark.

#### 2. Inadequate Planning

Rushing into execution without a structured plan is one of the most common project management mistakes. When milestones aren't mapped or dependencies go unnoticed, projects veer off track. Teams waste time reacting instead of progressing. Essential details get overlooked. Planning is about creating a foundation that supports accountability and transparency. A thoughtful and adaptable project plan provides direction to the work and keeps goals within reach.

#### 3. Poor Communication

When information doesn't move freely, projects stall. Updates get lost. Feedback arrives too late. Decisions lag behind real needs. Team members perform best when communication flows with purpose and context. Without that, assumptions grow and missteps follow. Fixing the work is more complicated than keeping everyone informed in the first place.

#### 4. Project Scope Creep

It starts small: one extra feature, a minor change, or a new request. However, without boundaries, these additions accumulate. Deadlines stretch. Budgets inflate. Teams lose sight of the original goal. Scope creep doesn't only delay delivery. It reshapes the project in ways no one agreed to. Managing it means protecting the work with firm priorities and a transparent process for evaluating change.

#### 5. Inefficient Resource Allocation

Putting the right people and tools in the wrong place slows everything down. Teams get overworked. Critical tasks sit idle. Deadlines slip while effort goes unused elsewhere. It's time we work smarter, not harder. Resource allocation should match skill with need, availability with urgency. When it doesn't, even simple projects become a struggle.

#### 6. Undermined Risk Management

Risks ignored are problems waiting to happen. When teams assume everything will go as planned, they miss early warning signs. Delays, shortages, and missteps creep in unnoticed.

Risk management is about being prepared and vigilant. Projects run more smoothly when potential setbacks are identified, flagged, and addressed before they escalate.

### **7. Unrealistic Deadlines**

Setting deadlines without input from the team leads to burnout. Tasks get rushed. Corners get cut. Quality takes a hit. Timelines should accurately reflect the actual scope of the work, rather than being influenced by wishful thinking or pressure from above. When schedules are grounded in reality, teams can focus, deliver consistently, and adjust when needed without losing trust. A deadline should drive momentum, not destroy team morale.

### **8. Insufficient Stakeholder Engagement**

Leaving stakeholders out of key moments creates disconnects. Expectations shift. Support fades. Decisions get second-guessed. Engagement doesn't mean constant updates. When stakeholders feel heard and informed, projects gain clarity and direction. Without that connection, alignment breaks down, and rework follows. Stakeholders are part of the process. Treating them that way changes everything.

## **4 Reading 2: “Project Management Methodologies”**

(adapted from *teamwork.com*)

A project management methodology is a set of principles and practices that guide you in organizing your projects to ensure their optimum performance. Basically, it's a framework that helps you to manage your project in the best way possible.

No two projects are exactly the same. That's why it makes sense that there's no one-size-fits-all approach to managing a project.

There are lots of factors that will impact which project management methodology is right for your project, team, and organization. Here's a quick breakdown of some of the key considerations that can help you decide:

- Cost & budget
- Team size
- Ability to take risks
- Flexibility
- Timeline
- Client / Stakeholder collaboration

### **Waterfall methodology**

The Waterfall method is a traditional approach to project management. In it, tasks and phases are completed in a linear, sequential manner, and each stage of the project must be completed before the next begins. Progress flows in one direction, like a real waterfall.

Also like a real waterfall, though, this can quickly get dangerous. Since everything is mapped out at the beginning, there's a lot of room for error if expectations don't match up with reality. And there's no going back to a previous stage once it's completed.

Try this project management methodology if:

- The end goal of your project is clearly defined and isn't going to change.
- The stakeholders know exactly what they want (and it isn't going to change).
- Your project is consistent and predictable (i.e. isn't going to change).
- You're working in a regulated industry that needs extensive project tracking or documentation.
- You might need to bring new people into the project midway through and get them up to speed quickly.

### **Agile Methodology**

The agile project management methodology came from a growing dissatisfaction with the linear approach of traditional project management methodologies. Frustrated with the limitations of project management methods that couldn't adapt with a project as it progressed, the focus began to shift to more iterative models that allowed teams to revise their project as needed during the process instead of having to wait until the end to review and amend.

The concept of agile project management has gone on to spark several specific sub-frameworks and methodologies, such as scrum, kanban, and lean. But what do they all have in common? The key principles of agile project management methodologies are: It's collaborative, it's quick and it's open to data-driven change.

As such, agile project management methodologies usually involve short phases of work with frequent testing, reassessment, and adaptation throughout. In many agile methods, all of the work to be done is added to a backlog that teams can work through in each phase or cycle, with project managers or product owners prioritizing the backlog so teams know what to focus on first.

#### Try this project management methodology if:

- Your project is liable to change.
- You're not sure at the outset what the solution will look like.
- You need to work quickly, and it's more important that you see speedy progress than perfect results.
- Your stakeholders or client needs (or wants) to be involved at every stage.

## **5 Gantt Charts**

(adapted from *gantt.com*)

A Gantt chart, commonly used in project management, is one of the most popular and useful ways of showing activities (tasks or events) displayed against time. On the left of the chart is a list of the activities and along the top is a suitable time scale. Each activity is represented by a bar; the position and length of the bar reflects the start date, duration and end date of the activity. This allows you to see at a glance:

- What the various activities are
- When each activity begins and ends
- How long each activity is scheduled to last
- Where activities overlap with other activities, and by how much

- The start and end date of the whole project

The project team breaks down each Work Breakdown Structure (WBS) into activities. Too many activities can be as bad as too few. It is also important to identify deadlines and milestones while decomposing the project.

Every activity is related to one or more other activities. Every activity, except the first and last, has a relationship with a predecessor and a successor. There are four types of relationships:

**1. Finish to Start (=sequential)**

Cannot start the successor activity until its predecessor is finished.

**2. Start to Start (=parallel / overlapping)**

Cannot start the successor activity until its predecessor has started.

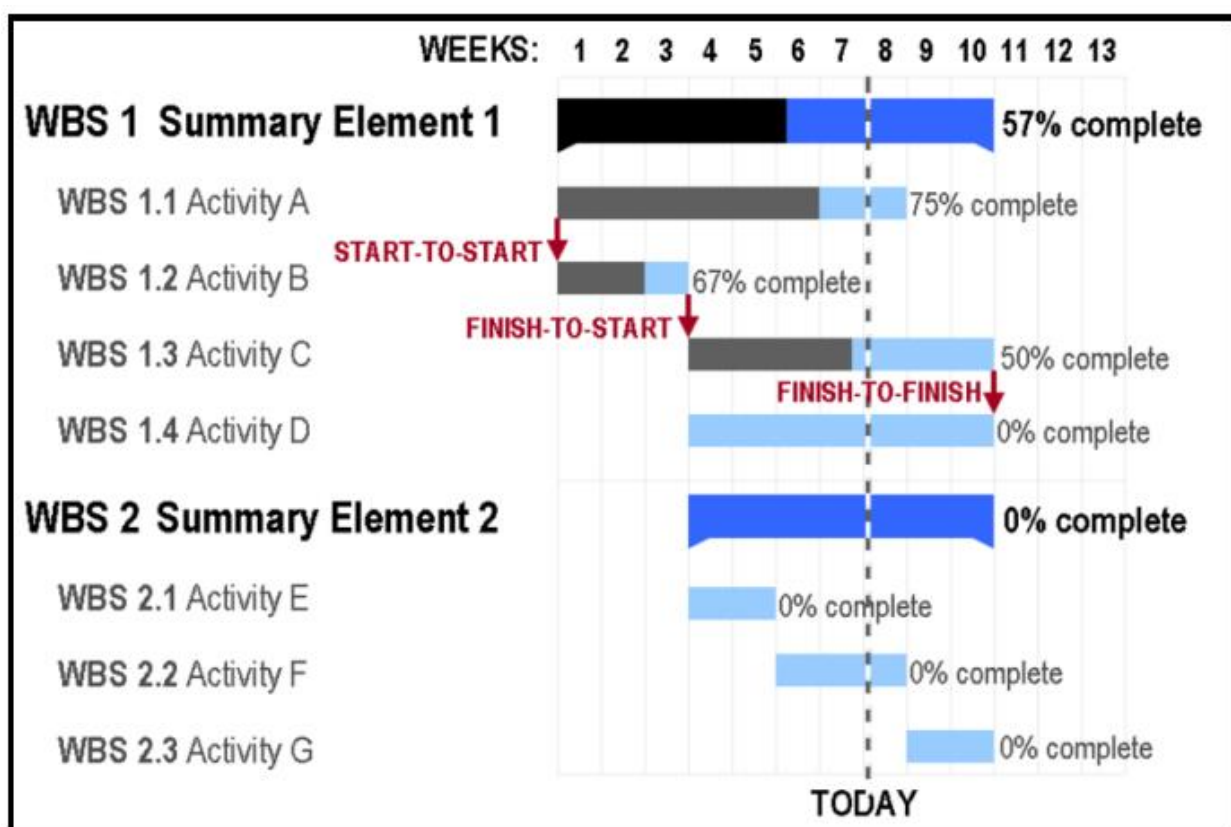
**3. Start to Finish**

Cannot finish the successor activity until its predecessor had started.

**4. Finish to Finish**

Cannot finish the successor activity until its predecessor has finished.

Relationships 1 and 2 are the most commonly used. Finish to Start is a sequential relationship and Start to Start is typically a parallel or over-lapping relationship.



## 6 Useful Language

When discussing a team project, it is important that we differentiate between factual and personal comments, especially when giving feedback. In addition, in English we tend to be less direct and more polite when we voice our opinion.

Here are some useful phrases which you can use for our project- and/or team meetings.

| Function                | Examples                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|-------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Stating an opinion      | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• <i>In my opinion...</i></li> <li>• <i>The way I see it...</i></li> <li>• <i>If you want my honest opinion....</i></li> <li>• <i>According to Lisa...</i></li> <li>• <i>As far as I'm concerned...</i></li> <li>• <i>Personally, I think...</i></li> <li>• <i>If you ask me...</i></li> </ul>                                                                             |
| Asking for an opinion   | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• <i>What's your idea?</i></li> <li>• <i>What are your thoughts on all of this?</i></li> <li>• <i>How do you feel about that?</i></li> <li>• <i>What do you think?</i></li> <li>• <i>Do you agree?</i></li> <li>• <i>Wouldn't you say?</i></li> </ul>                                                                                                                      |
| Expressing agreement    | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• <i>I couldn't agree with you more.</i></li> <li>• <i>You're absolutely right.</i></li> <li>• <i>That's exactly how I feel.</i></li> <li>• <i>I'm afraid I agree with James.</i></li> <li>• (agree with negative statement) <i>Me neither.</i></li> <li>• <i>You have a point there (, but...).</i></li> <li>• <i>I agree with you up to a point.</i></li> </ul>          |
| Expressing disagreement | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• <i>Not necessarily.</i></li> <li>• <i>That's not always true.</i></li> <li>• <i>That's not always the case.</i></li> <li>• <i>No, I'm not so sure about that.</i></li> <li>• <i>I'm afraid I disagree.</i></li> <li>• <i>I beg to differ.</i></li> <li>• (strong) <i>I'd say the exact opposite.</i></li> <li>• (strong) <i>I totally disagree.</i></li> </ul>           |
| Clarifying a point      | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• <i>What I really mean is...</i></li> <li>• <i>What I'm trying to say is...</i></li> <li>• <i>My point is...</i></li> <li>• <i>What do you mean by that?</i></li> <li>• <i>I'm sorry, what do you mean exactly?</i></li> <li>• <i>Are you saying...?</i></li> </ul>                                                                                                       |
| Interruptions           | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• <i>Can I add something here?</i></li> <li>• <i>Is it okay if I jump in for a second?</i></li> <li>• <i>If I might add something...</i></li> <li>• <i>Sorry to interrupt, but...</i></li> <li>• (after accidentally interrupting someone) <i>Sorry, go ahead. OR Sorry, you were saying...</i></li> <li>• (after being interrupted) <i>Can I finish first?</i></li> </ul> |

Making suggestions

- *Let's...*
- *How about* (noun/verb + *-ing*)...?
- *Why don't you/we...?*
- *I think you/we should...*
- *Why not* (verb + *-ing*)...?
- *Wouldn't it be better to...?*